Democracy's Data: Analytics and Insights into American Elections

[84–355] | Fall 2026

Prof. Jonathan Cervas

Updated: August 21, 2026

> Professor Jonathan Cervas
> Office: Posner Hall 374
> Email: **cervas@cmu.edu**
> Location: Porter Hall A21A
> Time: Tuesday & Thursday 11:00a-12:20p Eastern
> Office Hours: Wed 10:30a-12:30p & 1:30p-3:30p, and by appointment (arrange via email)
> **CMU Academic Calendar**

The most up-to-date version of this **syllabus can be found here**: https://jcervas.github.io/teaching/2026-2027/class-cmu-2026-84-355/readme.html

---

> **Course Relevance:** DC: *Perspectives on Justice and Injustice* **Learning Resources:** All resources will be provided via Canvas
> **Prerequisites:** 36-200 Reasoning with Data

25 meetings, Tuesdays and Thursdays. One of them, **Tue, Nov 24**, meets on Zoom rather than in the room. The tinted days are closures — fall break, Democracy Day, Thanksgiving, and the Constitution Day Symposium.

01 Course Description

The point of this course is to understand the political world — particularly through the data it produces. American elections generate an enormous amount of it: vote returns reaching back to the nineteenth century, the census that decides how many seats each state gets, campaign finance filings, polls, roll-call votes, and the record of who turned out and who did not. Every one of those numbers was produced by somebody, for a purpose, and every one of them leaves something out.

We work with real data every week — 41 presidential elections since 1864, the apportionment that followed the 2020 census, FEC filings, congressional roll calls, Census and American Community Survey estimates, and the 2026 midterms as they happen. Tuesdays are for the week's reading and the argument it raises; Thursdays are for the data, worked through together.

This is a general education course and there is no coding prerequisite. Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief with the results already in front of you. What you are asked to do is read it closely, follow how the numbers were made, and explain what you are looking at. The skill being built is not programming; it is judgment about evidence. You will practise it on a data-driven news story written for real readers, and defend it in class every week.

02 Course Goals

This course has one central aim: that you leave able to **look at a number about American democracy and know what to ask of it**. Who produced it, what it counts, what it leaves out, and whether it supports the claim being made in its name.

Everything else — the readings, the labs, the project — serves that.

03 Learning Objectives

By the end of the semester you will be able to:

1. **Explain where American election data comes from** — who produces it, at what geographic level, and what each source does and does not capture. *(Units I and V)*
2. **Read a table, chart, or map of electoral data and say plainly what it shows, what it does not show, and what would have to be true for its conclusion to hold.** *(every unit; this is the core skill)*

3. **Test a claim about elections against the underlying data** — whether the claim comes from a news story, a campaign, or a scholarly argument. *(Units II and III)*
4. **Explain the institutions that convert votes into power**: the Electoral College, apportionment, districting, and the Voting Rights Act. *(Units I, IV, V)*
5. **Recognise when a number misleads** — through selective framing, mismatched units of analysis, or a model that gets the right answer for the wrong reason. *(every unit)*
6. **Write about quantitative evidence for a non-technical audience** — in journalistic form at length, and briefly every week on the discussion board. *(the data journalism project; the board)*

Each unit below states which of these it is building. If at any point you cannot tell why we are doing something, that is a failure of my design and not of your attention — please say so, and I will fix it.

04 Required Text

John Sides, Daron Shaw, Matt Grossmann & Keena Lipsitz. *Campaigns and Elections*. New York: W. W. Norton. ISBN 978-1-324-11504-5.

Readings from the text provide the **context** for each week. Expect to read one chapter before Tuesday, when we discuss it, and to spend Thursday working with data — the weekly draw, then the lab. Chapters are short — budget about an hour.

There is nothing else to buy.

Current events

The textbook is the context; the news is the test. A textbook chapter is settled by the time it prints, and this one went to press before the campaign you are living through. The point of this course is to understand the political world — above all through the data it produces — and a chapter alone cannot do that, because politics keeps happening after the book is finished.

We also happen to be meeting during a midterm cycle, which means the week's reading and the week's news will sometimes land on the same question. When that happens it is worth taking advantage of. It is a convenience, though, not the design: the reason to read a news story next to a chapter is that together they tell you more about how politics works than either does alone.

So most weeks carry **one or two short current-events items alongside the chapter** — a news article, an interactive, a newsletter post, sometimes a podcast episode. They are listed in the schedule below and posted on Canvas. They are not optional and not background: they are usually what the Tuesday discussion actually argues about, because they are where the chapter's claim either holds up or does not.

The schedule's links are a starting set. A syllabus written in August cannot know what November will produce. Expect items to be added during the term, always to Canvas. If the schedule and Canvas disagree, Canvas is right.

These are also where your weekly data slide comes from. You are not expected to go hunting in unfamiliar places. Anything below is fair game, and so is anything else you can source and name.

	Worth following all term
General	*New York Times* (especially The Upshot), *Washington Post*, *Wall Street Journal* — all three are free to you through the CMU Libraries
Elections specialists	Bolts, Votebeat, Stateline, Democracy Docket, Cook Political Report, Sabato's Crystal Ball
Data and forecasting	Strength In Numbers (G. Elliott Morris), Silver Bulletin, Split Ticket, The Downballot
Podcasts	*The Ezra Klein Show* (NYT) · *NPR Politics Podcast* · *The Downballot* (weekly, Thursdays) · *Amicus* (Slate) · *Public Opinion Podcast* (AAPOR)

Where a specific episode is assigned it appears in the schedule marked **Podcast:**, the same way readings and labs are marked. Five weeks carry one.

None of these is required reading in itself. Pick two or three and actually follow them; that is worth more than skimming all of them once.

05 What you need

This is not a programming course, and there is no coding prerequisite.

There is no software to install and nothing to set up. Every lab arrives as a prepared data brief — the source, the decisions behind it, and the figures already made — and your job is to read it, follow how the numbers were built, and above all *explain what you are looking at*. If you have never worked with data before, you are exactly who these labs are written for.

What you are graded on is the thinking, not the typing. Nothing you hand in this term asks you to produce code or a chart — what you hand in is what you made of what the data shows.

Bring a laptop to Thursday sessions if you have one; the briefs are web pages and they read well on a phone or on paper too. If you would rather work from a printout, say so and I will bring one.

06 How This Course Works

The same rhythm every week. Nothing in the schedule should ever surprise you.

Tuesday is for the reading. Thursday is for data.

When	What
Before Tuesday	Read the week's chapter — about an hour.
Tuesday, in class	The chapter: what it claims, what it shows, who disputes it, and what would settle it.
Before Thursday	Post a data slide bearing on the question we ended Tuesday with.
Thursday, in class	The data draw (first 15 minutes), then the lab. We work through it together; submit what you have at the end of class, which also records your attendance.
Thursday evening or Friday	Post once to the discussion board about any of the data we talked about that week. Due **Friday, 11:59 p.m.**

Every week ends with a post to the discussion board, due **Friday, 11:59 p.m.**, the day after we work through data together. The deadline is close on purpose: reflect while it is still fresh, not four days later when all you remember is that there was a table.

A few sentences to a paragraph. What the post has to do is show that you were in the room and thinking about what was on the screen — name the number, the slide, or the finding you mean, and say what you make of it. A short post that does that beats a long one that could have been written by somebody who never turned up.

Write about **any of the data we talked about that week**. Usually that will be Thursday's lab, because it is what we spent the most time on. But a classmate's data slide from the draw, or a chart in the week's reading, or a number in one of the news items is equally fair game — if we looked at it together, you can write about it.

One post is all it takes. Do any *one* of these:

- **Something that surprised you.** A number that was not what you expected. Say what you expected and why, then what the data actually showed.
- **Something we missed.** A question the lab did not ask, a comparison it did not make, a group or a year it left out. You do not have to answer it — noticing it is the contribution.
- **Something you do not understand.** Genuinely. Not a performance of confusion: a real question about what a number means or why a method works. These are the most useful posts on the board and they are graded as generously as any other.
- **Or answer somebody.** Replying to a classmate counts as your post for the week, and a good answer is worth as much as a good question.

That last one matters. A board where everybody asks and nobody answers is not a discussion. If you know something, say so.

No code, no charts, no screenshots. Write what you made of what you saw.

Tuesday: the reading

Tuesday has as much shape as Thursday does. We make the same four moves every week, in this order, and by the end of the hour we have turned a chapter into a question that data could answer.

1. The claim	*15 min*	What is this chapter actually asserting? We put one sentence on the board and argue about the wording until it says something that could be wrong. "Campaigns matter" is not a claim. "Campaign spending changes vote share in House races" is.
2. The evidence	*20 min*	What does the chapter offer in support — a number, a study, a case, an anecdote, or nothing at all? Textbooks state a great many things without showing you why. Finding the unsupported sentences is not a criticism of the book; it is the exercise.
3. The disagreement	*30 min*	Who disputes this, and on what grounds? Each Tuesday names two of the four standards from Chapter 1 — free choice, political equality, deliberation, free speech — and a question that forces you to trade one against the other. The reference sheet at the end of this syllabus explains all four. We take sides — you will often be asked to argue the position you do not hold.
4. The test	*15 min*	What evidence would settle it? We end by writing down one question that data could answer.

Move 4 is the handoff. The question we end Tuesday with is the prompt for the data you post before Thursday. You are not hunting for something interesting in the abstract; you are looking for evidence bearing on a question the room agreed was worth asking two days earlier — and on Thursday we find out whether anybody could.

What to bring on Tuesday. The chapter, read, and **one sentence in it you would want to see tested.** You will not hand that in, and I may ask you for it.

07 Structure of the Course

The course has three layers, and every week runs all three.

Layer	Where	The question it answers
Prepared data	your weekly data slide, and the draw	*What is being claimed?*
Underlying data	**Thursday's data session**	***Where did that number come from?***
Why it matters	Tuesday's chapter, and Thursday's reading	*Why should anyone care?*

The loop is the point. You bring a chart on Tuesday. On Thursday we open the file it was built from and find out what had to be decided, discarded or guessed to produce it. The readings tell you why anyone bothered.

Tuesdays are for the chapter and the argument it raises. **Thursdays** are one source of data, start to finish — the weekly draw, then the lab.

The data sessions

They come in three parts, and the parts are a claim about who collected the data and why. The state **enumerates**, and you are required by law to answer (I). Somebody **asks**, and you answer because you feel like it (II). Then an election happens, and Part III is everything it leaves behind: the state **certifies** the result and **administers** the machinery that produced it, a candidate **discloses** because a statute compels it, an ordinary person is in the file having been asked nothing at all, and where nobody collected anything a researcher **built** the number.

Pt		Sessions
I	The Census Bureau	**1–3**
II	Surveys	**4–6**
III	Elections, and the records around them	**7–12**

Which source each Thursday takes is set week by week in the schedule below, not here — the part is the promise, the particular file is not.

The order is cumulative: nothing is inferred from a source you have not already met. The census (Part I) comes before the districts drawn on top of it. Surveys (II) come before the models built out of them. Returns (III) come before we ask who cast them, and the voter file — the other half of the same part — comes before we guess race from it. By the last sessions you are being asked to judge a number rather than read one, which only works because you already know where every part of it came from.

Session 10 is fixed to Nov 5 and is the only session whose date is not ours to choose: it runs on returns that do not exist until Nov 3, and everything around it is arranged to suit.

The textbook runs on its own track — not tied to the parts. We read it straight through, Chapters 1 to 13, and the three tests are the blocks that fall between: Ch. 1–5, Ch. 6–9, Ch. 10–13. They cover the textbook and nothing else.

The book's own briefs turn up in class. The book being built for this course is made of short written walkthroughs — one file, one chart, ten numbered steps, no code. They are teaching material rather than homework: which one a session uses is decided on the day, mostly on Thursdays. Nothing to read in advance, nothing to install.

08 Assessment

The course grade will be a weighted average of the following components:

Category	Percent of Final Grade
Participation & Attendance	23%
Discussion Board	10%
Surveys (3, completion only)	2%
Weekly Data Contributions	10%
Three Tests (10% each)	30%
Data Journalism Project	25%

What each one is:

- **Participation & Attendance** — Being here, prepared, and in the conversation — on both days.
- **Discussion Board** — By Friday night each week, one post about any of the data we talked about: the lab, a classmate's data slide, a figure in the reading. Something that surprised you, something we missed, something you do not understand, or an answer to somebody else's question. **A few sentences to a paragraph** — enough to show you engaged with what we did. One post is full credit.
- **Surveys** — Three short ones: the **Cervas Election Study** in Week 1, a **midterm feedback** survey once you have seen how the course actually runs, and the **course evaluation** at the end. Graded for completion only — there are no right answers, and nothing you say affects any other part of your grade.
- **Weekly Data Contributions** — Find data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, name the source, and post it as a slide before Thursday. Each week two slides are drawn at random and worked through in class, and nobody presents the data they found themselves — expect your own data to come up once or twice all term. The slide is marked complete or incomplete each week. At the end of term you hand in a **newsletter**: every piece

of data you found, each with a short write-up. **Build it as you go** — it is a paragraph a week, and an evening's work if you leave it all to December.

- **Three Tests** — In class, on paper, and **on the textbook only**. Test 1 on **Thu, Oct 8** (Sides et al., Chapters 1–5), Test 2 on **Tue, Nov 10** (Chapters 6–9), Test 3 on **Thu, Dec 3** (Chapters 10–13). We read the book straight through in its own order, so each test is a block of consecutive chapters: each covers the chapters read since the last one, **none is cumulative**, and every chapter appears on exactly one test. There is no final exam.
- **Data Journalism Project** — A data-driven news story about a trend or issue in electoral processes. Runs in three parts — draft, peer review, final — and **most of the marks are on the first two**. It is the only substantial piece of writing this term.

09 Due Dates

Assignment	Due
Data slide	before **each Thursday**
Surveys (3)	**Wed, Aug 26** (Cervas Election Study), **Fri, Oct 23** (midterm feedback), **final week** (course evaluation)
Discussion board post	**Friday, 11:59 p.m.**, each week
Data Session 4 board post (no Thursday session)	**Tue, Sep 22** — no session to follow that week, so you get the weekend
Week 14 board post (Thanksgiving)	**Mon, Nov 30** — Tuesday is on Zoom, and there is no Thursday
Test 1 — Ch. 1–5	**Thu, Oct 8**, in class
Data journalism: pitch	**Tue, Oct 20**, in class
Test 2 — Ch. 6–9	**Tue, Nov 10**, in class
Data journalism: **draft**	**Thu, Nov 19** — the last session before the break
Data journalism: **peer reviews** (two)	**Tue, Dec 1**
Test 3 — Ch. 10–13	**Thu, Dec 3**, in class
Data newsletter	**Tue, Dec 8**
Data journalism: **final**	**Fri, Dec 11** — after the last session

There is no final exam.

10 Assignment Details

1. **Current Events Data Snippets**
   Every week you find a piece of data bearing on the question Tuesday ended with, and bring it to class. Some weeks yours will be what the room works on. which weeks in advance.
   Before Thursday. Post one slide to the shared deck (link on Canvas):

- **The data** — a figure, a chart, a table, a map. It can be one number or a hundred.
- **The source**, named and linked — not "a study," but who published it
- **One sentence** on what you think it shows
- **Where you got it**, if you did anything to it — cropped a chart, took one row out of a table, converted a count into a percentage. Say so.

It has to bear on the question we ended Tuesday with. Every Tuesday closes by writing down one question that data could answer — that is move 4 of *Tuesday: the reading*, above. Your slide is your attempt at evidence for it. Read the question broadly; an odd angle is welcome. But do not bring turnout data to a week that ended on a question about the media.

That constraint is the point. When a dozen people go looking at the same subject, **they come back with data that disagree**, and working out why is most of what this course is about. You will not have to manufacture the disagreement. It arrives on its own.

> **Example.** *Voter turnout*: "About two-thirds (66%) of the voting-eligible population turned out for the 2020 presidential election." — Pew Research Center
> Note the phrase "voting-eligible population." Somebody else will arrive with turnout data built on a different denominator, and the two will not match. Neither of them is wrong.

What the groups discuss. The same three questions every week — the questions this whole course is about:

1. **What does it measure?** Who produced this, what exactly does it count, and what does it leave out?
2. **Does anyone else's data bear on it?** Agree, disagree, complicate. If two of you have data about the same thing that do not match, stop and work out why — that is the best thing that can happen in this exercise.
3. **How would you put it in a couple of sentences** to somebody who had not seen it?

Question 3 is not decoration. It is the rehearsal for explaining the data to the room, and if your group cannot answer it, the presenter is about to find that out in front of everyone.

In class Thursday — about fifteen minutes, before the lab.

	What happens
1. Before class	I draw **two names**. Those two slides are on the screen when you walk in.
2. Four groups	We split into four groups. Two groups take the first piece of data, two take the second.

	What happens
3. The discussion *(7 min)*	Each group works its data using the three questions above. Anyone whose own data bears on it brings it in.
4. The second draw	Once discussion ends, I draw **one presenter for each piece of data** — from one of the two groups that worked it.
5. The floor *(6 min)*	Each presenter explains data, and what their group talked about. Then the **other groups** say where they read it differently. Anyone can contribute.

The two draws happen at different times, on purpose.
The first is made after the submission deadline and before class, so that the slides are already up and I have had a chance to read them. You will not know whose data we are working on until you walk in — and since you posted yours before I drew, that cannot affect what you brought.
The second is made **live, after the discussion is over**. Nobody knows who is presenting while the group is still talking, so the only safe strategy is to understand your group's data well enough to explain it yourself. Everybody prepares; two people speak.
Names are **not put back**. Once your name is drawn it stays out until "the cup" is empty and I "refill" it.
Nobody presents data they found themselves. If you cannot restate somebody else's data accurately, you did not understand it.
Why two groups take the same data. So that we can see two honest readings of an identical thing side by side. When the second group says "we read that differently," that is not a failure by either group. It is the most useful two minutes of the exercise.

Grading. The slide is marked complete/incomplete each week. There is no separate penalty for being drawn without one: a missing slide costs that week's credit, whether or not your name comes out.
What being drawn costs is not points. When your name comes out, the next fifteen minutes of the class are built on your having done a small piece of work. If you are not ready, I draw again and we carry on — but a room of nineteen people has been left waiting on you, and that is the reason to have something ready rather than a number in the gradebook.
Over a semester you can expect your own data to be drawn once or twice, and to present somebody else's about as often.

At the end: the newsletter. Your weekly contributions do not evaporate once the class has discussed them. In the last week of term you hand in a single document — a **newsletter** — collecting every piece of data you found this semester, each with a short write-up: what it measures, where it came from, and what you made of it once the room had worked it over. A paragraph apiece is plenty.

	Share of this component	What it is
Weekly slides	**70%**	The data you post before each session, marked complete/incomplete.
Newsletter	**30%**	The collected set, written up, handed in at the end.

Assemble it as you go. The work is already done by the time you get there — you found the data, and the class told you what it was worth. Written up in the week it happened, each entry takes ten minutes; written up in December from a folder of half-remembered links, the whole thing is an evening you did not need to spend. **Due Tue, Dec 8, 11:59 p.m.**
It is worth a small share of the grade and it is the only place your own term's work sits in one piece. Several of these will be a better portfolio of what you can do with data than anything else you hand in.

2. **Discussion Board**
    - We work through data together in class — the lab on Thursday, and before that the two slides drawn from the class. You submit what you have at the end of Thursday's session; this doubles as attendance.
    - **Then you post that evening or the next day**, on the course discussion board in Canvas. Due **Friday, 11:59 p.m.** One post a week, and one post is all that is needed for full credit.
    - **A few sentences to a paragraph.** What it has to do is show engagement with what we actually did in class. Say which number, slide or finding you mean and what you make of it. Running longer than a paragraph earns nothing on its own; running shorter usually means you have named something without saying what you make of it.
    - **You are not asked to write code, and not asked to produce a chart.** The post is about what you made of the data.

    Write about **any of the data we talked about that week** — the lab, a classmate's slide, a figure in the reading, a number in one of the news items. Do any one of these:

Something surprised you	Say what you expected and why, then what the data showed instead. The gap is the interesting part.
Something we missed	A question nobody asked, a comparison nobody made, a group or a year left out. You need not answer it; noticing counts.
Something you do not understand	A real question about what a number means or why a method works. These are the most valuable posts on the board.
An answer	Reply to a classmate. A good answer is worth as much as a good question, and counts as your post for the week.

Posts are graded on a four-point scale:

Score	What it looks like
4	Everything in a 3, plus something I did not ask for: a caveat about what the data cannot show, a connection to another week, or a question that sends the conversation somewhere.
3	A specific, well-supported point about the data — you name the number, you say what it means, and the reasoning holds. **This is the target. A 3 is good work.**
2	On topic but unanchored: a reaction rather than an observation, or a point that does not rest on anything we actually looked at.
1	Generic enough that it could have been written without attending.

A confused question, asked precisely, is a 3. Asking what you do not understand is not an admission that you fell behind — it is the most useful thing you can contribute, because if you are wondering it, so are six other people who have not said so.

A semester average of 75% earns an A−. Do not chase 4s; a consistent 3 is a strong grade.

3. **The data journalism project**

   A data-driven news story investigating a trend, pattern or issue in electoral processes, written for somebody who does not read this sort of thing for pleasure. **2–4 pages, with at least two figures**, worked into the text rather than parked at the end. The full rubric is on Canvas.

   The figures do not have to be ones you built yourself. A chart we made together in a lab is fine; so is a table you pull from data.census.gov, or a figure from one of the readings — provided you say what it shows, where it came from, and why it bears on your question. If you would rather make your own, the code in every lab is yours to adapt and I will help. **What is graded is whether the evidence supports the claim**, not whether you wrote the plotting code.

   One substantial piece of writing this term, worth **25%**, in three parts: a pitch in October, a full draft at the last session before the Thanksgiving break, and the revision after the term's final session. The reviews you write sit between the draft and the final, so the comments reach their author while there is still time to act on them.

	Share of the project	What it is
Pitch	**5%**	One paragraph on **Tue, Oct 20**, in class. Marked for having done it.
Draft	**50%**	A complete attempt — not an outline, not a sketch. Graded as though it were the finished piece.

	Share of the project	What it is
Peer review	**35%**	The two reviews **you write** for other people. Graded on how useful they are to the person receiving them.
Final	**10%**	The revision. Graded on what you changed and why, not re-graded from scratch.

Most of the marks are on the draft and the reviews, deliberately. The usual way a paper gets written is that nothing happens for three weeks and then something happens the night before, and the comments you get back arrive too late to matter. So the draft has a deadline of its own — **Thu, Nov 19** — and carries 50% on that date, and the two reviews you write carry another 35% on **Tue, Dec 1**. **The piece has to be finished once, three weeks early, before it is finished for good.** A strong draft and two genuinely useful reviews will carry you even if the revision is modest.
The corollary is that **the final is a small piece of the grade, and that is not an invitation to skip it.** Ten per cent is what a revision is worth when the work it revises was already done properly. It is not what the piece is worth. It also means **you cannot rescue a missing draft with a good final.** There is no version of this where the work starts late.

On the peer review. You will review two people's drafts, on a worksheet I provide, and they will review yours. What is graded is the review you *give*. A review that says "this is good, maybe add more data" is worth very little; a review that says "your second chart shows share and your argument needs counts, and I could not find where the 62% came from" is worth a great deal. Reviewing is a skill, it is most of what editors and referees actually do, and you will get better at your own writing by doing it.
On the final. Submit it with a short note — three or four sentences — on what you changed in response to the reviews and what you decided not to change and why. Declining to take advice is fine and sometimes right. Ignoring it silently is not.

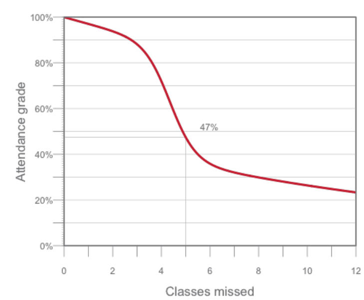
4. **Tests**
   Three, in class, on paper, **10% each**.

	When	Covers
Test 1	**Thu, Oct 8**	Sides et al., Ch. 1–5
Test 2	**Tue, Nov 10**	Sides et al., Ch. 6–9
Test 3	**Thu, Dec 3**	Sides et al., Ch. 10–13

All three cover the textbook only — not the labs, not the outside readings, not the data sessions. Each one covers the chapters assigned since the previous test, and none is cumulative.
We read the book straight through, 1 to 13. There is nothing to keep track of: the chapters arrive in the book's own order, each test is the block read

since the last one, and every chapter is read once and tested once. The book's internal references also come out right this way — Ch. 10 and 11 point back to campaign finance in Ch. 4, and several chapters point back to parties in Ch. 6, and you will have read both by the time they do.
The questions come from the publisher's test bank: multiple choice and short answer, on what the chapters say. This is the one part of the course that rewards ordinary studying, and it exists because the rest of the course grades interpretation, which is harder to prepare for by reading carefully. If you have kept up with the chapters, no separate preparation should be needed.
There is no final exam. Test 3 is an ordinary class session in the last week, not a cumulative exam: it covers Chapters 10–13 and nothing before them.
The data sessions are not tested. Twelve of them — the census, precinct returns, voter files, election administration, campaign finance, surveys, polls, roll calls, cast vote records, redistricting — and none of it is on a test, because none of it is in the textbook. It is assessed the way the rest of the course is assessed: by what you say in the room and what you post to the board. Do not read "not on the test" as "not important." **It is the half of the course the course is named after.**

5. **Attendance:**
Regular attendance and active involvement form a significant part of your final grade (see grading section). If you do not show up, you will not earn an 'A'. Participation is not just about being present; it involves engaging with the material, contributing to discussions, and collaborating with your peers. To recognize that occasional absences are sometimes unavoidable (e.g., for religious observance, job interviews, university-sanctioned events, or illness), attendance grades follow a curve with three stretches. The first three absences cost you almost nothing — that is what they are there for. From the fourth to the sixth the penalty bites hard, and this is the range where a semester goes wrong. After that the curve flattens into a long tail: each further absence still costs you, but less, and it never reaches zero. There is no point at which you may as well stop coming.



Absences and the attendance grade. The first three cost almost nothing; four to six is where it bites.

Classes missed	0	2	3	4	5	6	8	12
Attendance grade	100%	94%	88%	72%	47%	36%	30%	23%

If you must miss class, please notify me at least 24 hours in advance (unless it is an emergency or sudden illness) so we can arrange a way for you to catch up.[1]

[1] If you need to miss more than two sessions due to extenuating circumstances, let me know as soon as possible so we can discuss how best to support you.

---

6. **Surveys** (2%)
Three short surveys, each graded purely for completion. There are no right answers, nothing you say is graded on content, and nothing you say affects any other part of your grade.
   - **Week 1 — the Cervas Election Study.** Due **Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.** A survey instrument modelled on the Cooperative Election Study and the American National Election Study, but neither: items have been cut, reworded, and added. Your answers become a class dataset,

which I report back in aggregate and never individually. We set it against the real Cooperative Election Study in **Session 6**.

- **Mid-term — course feedback.** Due **Fri, Oct 23, 11:59 p.m.**, after the first test and the break, which is late enough that you have seen how the course actually runs and early enough that I can still change it.
- **Final week — the course evaluation.**

The first survey is anonymous: it asks no name, requires no login, and records nothing that identifies you — which also means it cannot tell me you completed it. So credit runs on a receipt: **after you submit, screenshot the confirmation screen and upload it to the Canvas assignment.** The screenshot is your receipt; the survey data never learns who you are.

11 Grading

Your grade rests on engagement as much as on output. The course is built around two things happening every week — you arriving having read, and you arriving having found data — and neither can be made up afterwards.

Deadlines. You are expected to meet them. If you can see in advance that you will not, contact me **before** the due date and we will sort something out.

Late work loses **one percentage point per hour, and never falls below 50%**.[2] Canvas applies this automatically. Submit what you have rather than polishing something that is already late.

Work that is never submitted scores **zero**, which is the whole reason the late floor sits at 50%: handing something in a week late is always worth more than handing in nothing.

Two things sit outside that rule because being late breaks somebody else's work, not just your own:

- **Peer reviews.** Your classmate cannot revise against a review that has not arrived. Late reviews are marked down sharply.
- **Project drafts.** A missing draft means two people have nothing to review, and — as above — you cannot rescue a missing draft with a good final.

[2] An hour or two costs almost nothing; a day costs a letter grade. Charging by the hour rather than the day removes the cliff at midnight — being twenty minutes late should not cost the same as being twenty hours late. The floor is there so that late work is always worth more than no work.

12 Schedule

Week 1 — Part I opens

- **Tue, Aug 25** — Course introduction: the three layers. Read the book's own introduction, What This Book Is For.
  - The book's introduction — *What This Book Is For*
  - **DUE Wed, Aug 26, 11:59 p.m.** — the **Cervas Election Study**.
- **Thu, Aug 27** — Data Session 1 — The decennial census, and the seats it decides
  - Census Bureau, *America Counts: 250 Years*
  - Census Academy — the Census data API — module 1 only

  - NCSL, *Redistricting Law 2020*, ch. 1 — the census

Week 2 — Part I

- **Tue, Sep 1** — The rules, and the four standards
  - Sides et al., Ch. 1
  - Scott, *Seeing Like a State* (1998), intro — where "legibility" comes from
- **Thu, Sep 3** — Data Session 2 — Geography, and the scales it comes at
  - Census Bureau video — *Understanding Statistical Geographies*

Week 3 — Part I

- **Tue, Sep 8** — Who can vote, how, and where
  - Sides et al., Ch. 2
  - Cohn, *NYT* — the Electoral College edge
  - Brennan Center — census data and a changing nation
  - *NPR* — Black representation after the ruling
  - Podcast: *Amicus* (Slate)
- **Thu, Sep 10** — Data Session 3 — The American Community Survey
  - ACS Handbook, ch. 1 — the basics
  - Census Academy — *Discovering the American Community Survey* — all six modules

Week 4 — Part II opens

- **Tue, Sep 15** — The transformation of American campaigns
  - Sides et al., Ch. 3
- **Thu, Sep 17** — **NO CLASS.** Constitution Day Symposium. Data Session 4 is self-directed: what a survey can establish.
  - Pew — how public polling has changed
  - Pew — polling basics, lessons 1–3

Week 5 — Part II

- **Tue, Sep 22** — Money, and the rule that shapes everything after it
  - Sides et al., Ch. 4
- **Thu, Sep 24** — Data Session 5 — Election polls: the horse race, and what a margin hides
  - Bailey, *Polling at a Crossroads* (2023), ch. 1, 3–22
  - *NYT* — are political polls accurate?
  - Podcast: AAPOR on pre-election polling

Week 6 — Part II closes

- **Tue, Sep 29** — Strategy: who a campaign decides to talk to
  - Sabino, *Bolts* — Missouri's ballot-initiative vote
  - Sides et al., Ch. 5
- **Thu, Oct 1** — Data Session 6 — Public opinion, and the studies built to measure it: the Cervas Election Study beside CES and ANES. No slide, no draw.

- Verba, "The Citizen as Respondent" (1996), 1–7 — why measure opinion by survey at all
- Pew — writing survey questions — wording, order effects, response options
- *Reference:* Cooperative Election Study — how it samples, and how many it reaches
- *Reference:* American National Election Studies — the same two questions, answered differently
- *Reference: Harvard Youth Poll*, 52nd edition — toplines, and the methodology behind them

Week 7 — Test 1

- **Tue, Oct 6** — Who the electorate is. No new chapter — review Ch. 1–5; Test 1 is Thursday.
  - No new chapter — review Ch. 1–5 for Test 1
  - *NYT* — the rise of the multiracial right
- **Thu, Oct 8** — **TEST 1.** In class, on paper — Ch. 1–5
  - Nothing new — bring questions

Week 8 — FALL BREAK, no class (Oct 12–16) Test 1 is behind you. Nothing is due.

Week 9 — Part III opens

- **Tue, Oct 20** — Data Session 7 — Part III opens: what a return is, where you get one, and what forty of them show
  - Burness, *Bolts* — election data and voting rights
  - FairVote — *Monopoly Politics 2026*
  - **DUE: Data journalism story — pitch your topic** (one paragraph, in class).
- **Thu, Oct 22** — Data Session 8 — The bottom rungs: precincts and ballots
  - MIT Election Lab — why does anyone need precinct-level results? — what county totals lose, and why the boundaries move

Week 10 — Part III

- **Tue, Oct 27** — Parties and interest groups
  - Sides et al., Ch. 6 and Ch. 7
- **Thu, Oct 29** — Data Session 9 — Money in politics: the record, and the hole in it
  - OpenSecrets — dark money basics — who must name a donor, and who need not
  - *NYT* — Harris's donors, the graphics — a disclosure file, drawn
  - *NYT* — Trump's campaign-finance disclosures — the same instrument as a problem
  - Podcast: *The Downballot* on this cycle's money

Week 11 — Part III · election night

- **Tue, Nov 3** — **NO CLASS.** Democracy Day. Read both chapters this week, for Thursday.
  - For Thursday: Sides et al., Ch. 8 and Ch. 9
- **Thu, Nov 5** — **Fixed date.** Data Session 10 — Live returns. Built on results that do not exist until Nov 3.
  - NPR — *Race calls 101*

Week 12 — Part III · the machinery

- **Tue, Nov 10** — **TEST 2.** In class, on paper — Ch. 6–9
  - Ch. 8 and 9 are on the test
- **Thu, Nov 12** — Data Session 11
  - *Session and reading to be set.*

Week 13 — Part III

- **Tue, Nov 17** — Congressional, state and local campaigns
  - Sides et al., Ch. 10 and Ch. 11
  - Morris — the hidden axis
- **Thu, Nov 19** — Data Session 12
  - *Session and reading to be set.*
  - **DUE: data journalism draft**.

Week 14 — the last two chapters

- **Tue, Nov 24** — **Remote.** The last two chapters — who turns out, and how they choose. On Zoom. No data session, no slide.
  - Sides et al., Ch. 12 and Ch. 13 — both on Test 3
  - *Source your own:* a news piece quoting a margin of error, or a demographic estimate
- **Thu, Nov 26** — **NO CLASS.** Thanksgiving. Read Ch. 12 and Ch. 13 over the break, for Test 3.

Week 15 — Part III, and the end

- **Tue, Dec 1** — The end of the argument — the law, the maps, and whether the thing itself can be measured.
  - Moynihan — *Power, Democracy and Clarity* — the Court's voting-rights turn after *Callais*
  - Monmonier, *Drawing the Line*, ch. 5 — borrow from the Internet Archive
  - *NYT* — gerrymandered districts aren't always ugly
  - Two ballot measures: California Prop 50 (passed), and Virginia (passed, then voided)
  - V-Dem — scoring democracy itself, for every country, every year
  - **DUE: peer reviews of the data journalism draft** — two each.
- **Thu, Dec 3** — **TEST 3.** In class, on paper — Ch. 10–13, then the course wrap

  - Nothing to read — bring questions

Finals period — there is no exam.

- **DUE Tue, Dec 8** — **the data newsletter**.
- **DUE Fri, Dec 11** — **data journalism story, final version**.

---

13 AI Use Policy for Student Work

As artificial intelligence (AI) tools become increasingly accessible, it is important to clarify expectations for their use in this course. You are welcome to use AI technologies (such as ChatGPT, Grammarly, or similar tools) to support your independent work—such as brainstorming ideas, checking grammar, or improving the clarity of your writing. However, you **may not use AI to generate substantive content that you submit as your own original work**. All assignments, essays, and projects must reflect your own analysis, critical thinking, and voice.

Permitted Uses of AI:

- Outlining or organizing your thoughts
- Checking grammar, spelling, or clarity
- Generating ideas or prompts to help you get started
- Reviewing your own drafts for readability

Prohibited Uses of AI:

- Submitting AI-generated essays, paragraphs, or answers as your own work
- Using AI to complete assignments, discussion posts, or projects in place of your own effort
- Copying and pasting AI-generated content without substantial revision and personal input

If you use AI tools in your process, you must **disclose** how you used them in a brief note at the end of your assignment (e.g., "I used ChatGPT to help brainstorm ideas for my outline.").

Violations:
Submitting AI-generated content as your own is considered academic dishonesty and will be treated as a violation of the university's academic integrity policy.

If you have questions about what is or is not allowed, please ask before submitting your work.

14 Representation Statement

I am committed to including a broad range of perspectives in the readings and materials for this course. If you believe a critical voice is missing, please let me know so I can improve the syllabus now and in future offerings.

We must treat every individual with respect. We come from many different backgrounds, and this variety of viewpoints is fundamental to building and maintaining an equitable and inclusive campus community. "Representation" can refer to the ways we identify ourselves—race, color, national origin, language, sex, disability, age, sexual orientation, gender identity, religion, creed, ancestry, belief, veteran status, or genetic information, among others. Each of these identities shapes the perspectives our students, faculty, and staff bring to campus. Promoting these varied viewpoints not only fuels excellence and innovation but also advances the pursuit of justice. We acknowledge our imperfections while fully committing to the work—inside and outside our classrooms—of building and sustaining a campus community that embraces these core values.

Each of us is responsible for creating a safer, more inclusive environment.

Unfortunately, incidents of bias or discrimination do occur, whether intentional or unintentional. They contribute to an unwelcoming atmosphere for individuals and groups at the university. Therefore, the university encourages anyone who experiences or observes unfair or hostile treatment on the basis of identity to speak out for justice and seek support—either in the moment or afterward. You can share your experiences using the following resources:

- **Ethics Reporting Hotline**
  Submit an anonymous report by calling 844-587-0793 or visiting **cmu.ethicspoint.com**.
  All reports are documented and reviewed to determine whether further action is needed. Regardless of the incident type, the university will use your feedback to transform our campus climate into one that is more equitable and just.

15 Accommodations for Students with Disabilities

If you have a documented disability and an accommodations letter from the Office of Disability Resources, please discuss your needs with me as early in the semester as possible. I will work with you to ensure that accommodations are provided as appropriate. If you suspect you may have a disability and are not yet registered with the Office of Disability Resources, you can contact them at **access@andrew.cmu.edu**.

16 Student Well-Being

The past few years have been challenging. We are all under significant stress and uncertainty. I encourage you to find ways to move regularly, eat well, and reach out to your support system—or to me at **cervas@cmu.edu**—if you need help. We can all benefit from support during stressful times, and this semester is no exception.

As a student, you may experience a range of challenges that interfere with learning, such as strained relationships, increased anxiety, substance use, feeling down, difficulty concentrating, or lack of motivation. These mental health concerns or stressful events can diminish your academic performance and reduce your ability to participate in daily activities. CMU offers services that can help, and treatment does work. Learn more about confidential mental health services available on campus at:

- **Counseling and Psychological Services**: http://www.cmu.edu/counseling/
  Phone (24/7): 412-268-2922

Please remember that support is always available—don't hesitate to reach out.